British Perspective (One of the Big Four)

Maintaining the unity of the British Empire, its holdings, and its interests, were the largest concerns of the British delegation. However, their specific goals (in this order) included ensuring the security of France, removing the threat of the German High Seas Fleet, settling territorial disputes, and demanding and supporting Wilson's League of Nations. Britain also believed that Germany should be made to pay for the war through reparations. At the same time, they believed that Germany should be rehabilitated as soon as possible to stabilize international trade. Germany was one of the most industrialized nations in the world and, as such, was not only an exporter, but a great importer of British materials and goods. Britain needed German trade for both economic and political reasons and wished to demand economic reparations from Germany. Although you recognize the contributions and sacrifices of Indian soldiers, petitions for Indian self-rule will not be up for discussion at this meeting since they are the "Crown of the Jewel." David Lloyd George, the Prime Minister, claimed that he did not do badly at the peace conference, "considering I was seated between Jesus Christ and Napoleon." This was a reference to the very idealistic views of Woodrow Wilson (US President) and George Clemenceau (France), who were determined to see Germany punished.

HINTS:

1. Use statistics to emphasize how much your citizenry lost during the war (these statistics include both those from the UK, as well as from their colonies).
    a. Civilian casualties included almost 17,000 from military action, another 100,000 from hunger and disease and another 225,000 from the Influenza pandemic.
    b. 1.5 million British soldiers were injured.
    c. 250,000 British Soldiers suffered a partial or full amputation as a result of fighting in the First World War.
    d. 744,000 military deaths
    e. Almost 2.5% of the total population died (over 1 million people) .
    f. (NOTE: THE COUNTRY WITH THE MOST MILITARY DEATHS WAS GERMANY—2 million)
2. Show no mercy to Germany.

Resources to Use:

Aims of the Big Three
The Treaty of Versailles | History of Western Civilization II
Lloyd George at the Conference
Treaty of Versailles Centennial: British Aims in Paris | Peace Palace Library

French Approach (One of the Big Four)

Between 1914 and 1918, 7.9 million French citizens were called to serve in the armed forces. In addition to these, 600,000 more soldiers from the colonies (who were not French citizens), enlisted in the army and about 500,000 saw combat in Europe. Over 4.2 million soldiers were wounded, over 500,000 were taken prisoner and roughly 1.4 million were killed. Afterwards, during the Paris Peace Conference, the French Prime Minister, George Clemenceau's chief goal was to weaken Germany militarily, strategically, and economically. Having personally witnessed two German attacks on French soil in the previous forty years, he was adamant that Germany should not be permitted to attack France again. In particular, Clemenceau sought an American and British guarantee of French security in the event of another German attack. Clemenceau also expressed skepticism and frustration with Wilson's Fourteen Points: "Mr. Wilson bores me with his fourteen points," complained Clemenceau. "Why, God Almighty has only ten!" Wilson did sign a mutual defense treaty with France, but back in Washington, the Senate refused to ratify it. Another alternative French policy was to seek a rapprochement [an establishment or resumption of harmonious relations] with Germany.

In May 1919 the diplomat Rene Massigli was sent on several secret missions to Berlin. During his visits, Massigli offered on behalf of his government to revise the territorial and economic clauses of the upcoming peace treaty. Massigli told the Germans that the French thought of the "Anglo-Saxon powers," namely the US and the British empire as a major threat to France in the post-war world. He argued that both France and Germany had a joint interest in opposing "Anglo-Saxon" domination of the world and warned that the "deepening of opposition" between the French and the Germans "would lead to the ruin of both countries, to the advantage of the Anglo-Saxon powers." The Germans rejected the French offers because they considered the French overtures to be a trap to trick them into accepting the Versailles treaty "as is" and because the Germans thought the US was more likely to reduce the severity of the peace terms than France. In the end, it was the British who eased up slightly on the terms.

HINTS:

1. You want to emphasize how much you lost in terms of farmland, population, military and industrial capacity. Somebody must pay for your loss in global status, economic strength, and manpower.
2. You want to negotiate for anything that will weaken Germany—especially the German war machine. They have invaded you twice in the past forty years, and you want to cripple their ability to do so again—that means industrially (remember they have overtaken you in recent years as an industrial superpower) and militarily (especially their navy).

Resources:

Aims of the Big Three

The Treaty of Versailles.

War Losses (France)

Georges Clemenceau | French Prime Minister & WWI Leader | Britannica

Italian Approach (One of the Big Four)

In 1882 Italy joined the German Empire and the Austro-Hungarian empire forming the Triple Alliance. During World War I, Italy aligned itself with the Allies, instead of joining its allies in the Triple Alliance. In the Treaty of London in 1915, Britain and France promised Italy a great deal of territory that had been part of the Austro-Hungarian empire, including parts north of Italy, much of the Balkans, and a share of Turkish and German empires in Africa. Vittorio Orlando was sent as the Italian representative with the aim of gaining these and as much other territory as possible. The loss of 700,000 Italians and a budget deficit of 12 trillion Lire during the war made the Italian government and people feel entitled to these territories. By the end of the war, the Allies had made contradictory agreements with other nations, especially in Central Europe and the Middle East. In meetings of the Big Four, Orlando's diplomatic skills were hampered by his lack of English. While Italy did get Trentino to the Brenner, the Dalmatian port of Zara, the Island of Lagosta, and a couple of small German colonies. All other territories were promised to other nations since the great powers were worried about Italy's imperial ambitions. As a result of this, Orlando left the conference in a rage.

HINTS:

1. How did the Italians lose so many men?
2. What was significant about the Treaty of London?
3. What was the role of Italy in the drafting of the League of Nations covenant?
4. You may have to storm out of the Paris Peace Conference at some point.

Resources to Use:
Discussion of Italian claims begins at Paris Peace Conference

Italian delegates announce return to Paris Peace Conference

Vittorio Orlando | World War I, Treaty of Versailles, Paris Peace Conference | Britannica

Orlando, Vittorio Emanuele | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

American Approach (One of the Big Four)

President Woodrow Wilson's 14 Points helped to convince many in the world that a real peace was possible, especially Americans, Germans, and other Europeans, as well as the former subjects of the Ottoman Empire. Wilson's diplomacy and his vision for the future had set the conditions for the armistice that had ended the Great War. Wilson thought it was his duty and obligation to the people of the world to be at the negotiations (leaving the US as President for six months!). He tried to lead the United States towards a policy of interventionism—a move strongly resisted by some Americans back home who preferred to isolate the United States from further involvement in global conflict. Wilson worked to convince the French and the British delegations that peace would best be served by a less harsh treatment of Germany and its allies in Europe, as well as on what should be done with the Ottoman lands in the Middle East. He was not able to get many of his 14 points passed since France and Britain refused to compromise on the War Guilt clause (Article 231) whereas the United States did not encourage nor believe that the responsibility for the war placed on Germany was fair or warranted. It would not be until 1921 that the United States finally signed separate peace treaties with Germany, Austria, and Hungary. In the Middle East, negotiations were complicated by competing aims, claims, and the new mandate system.

The United States hoped to establish a more liberal and diplomatic world, where democracy, sovereignty, liberty, and self-determination would be respected. France and Britain, on the other hand, already controlled empires, and wished to remain dominant colonial powers. In light of the previously secret Sykes-Picot agreement, and following the adoption of the mandate system on the Arab province of the former Ottoman lands, the conference heard statements from competing Zionist and Arab claimants. President Woodrow Wilson then recommended an international commission of inquiry to ascertain the wishes of the local inhabitants. This was rejected by the French and the British, paving the way for the formation of a Zionist homeland in Palestine, what would later be Israel. France and Britain tried to appease the American President by consenting to the establishment of his League of Nations. However, because isolationist sentiment was strong and some of the articles in the League's charter conflicted with the US Constitution, the US never did ratify the Treaty of Versailles, nor join the League of Nations, which President Wilson had helped create, to further peace through diplomacy rather than war and conditions which can breed it.

HINTS:

1. Know the 14 points and which ones were not accepted at the Peace Conference
2. Understand what self-determination means to President Wilson, and what it means to small nations in Europe, Asia and Africa
3. Why was it believed that the League of Nations could preserve the peace?

Resources To Use:

Aims of the Big Three

Paris Peace Conference | National WWI Museum and Memorial

The Fourteen Points | National WWI Museum and Memorial

The Paris Peace Conference and the Treaty of Versailles

What America's Take on the Treaty of Versailles Can Teach Us

Japanese Approach

The Japanese delegation was headed by Marquess Saionji Kinmochi, Baron Makino Nobuaki, and 62 others, making a total of 64. The delegation focused on two demands: the inclusion of their racial equality proposal in the League's Covenant and Japanese territorial claims with respect to former German colonies, namely Shan Tung, and the Pacific Islands north of the Equator (the Marshall Islands, Micronesia, the Mariana Islands, and the Carolines.) The Japanese claim to Shan Tung was disputed by the Chinese. In 1914, at the outset of the war, Japan had seized the territory granted to Germany in 1897. Secret agreements with the Allies led to an eventual resolution in Japan's favor, leading to Article 156 of the Treaty of Versailles which transferred German concessions in Kiaochow, China to Japan rather than returning sovereignty to China.

This would later lead to the May Fourth Movement. The Japanese delegation still became unhappy after receiving only one-half of the rights of Germany and walked out of the conference. Japan proposed including a "racial equality clause" in the Covenant of the League of Nations on February 13 as an amendment to Article 21: "The equality of nations being a basic principle of the League of Nations, the High Contracting Parties, agree to accord as soon as possible to all alien nationals of states, members of the League, equal and just treatment in every respect-making no distinction, either in law or in fact, on account of their race or nationality." Because he knew that Great Britain was critical to the decision, President Wilson, as Conference chairman, ruled that a unanimous vote was required. However, the Australians had convinced Great Britain to also vote against it. The defeat of the proposal influenced Japan's turn from cooperation with the West to more militant nationalism

HINTS:

1. The Japanese were great diplomats in Paris, definitely turning what seemed like pro-Chinese feelings by the west into pro-Japanese decisions. Be sure you know how they did this? What was the deal with those secret treaties?
2. Japan wanted to be considered a major power by the West. Their loss of face in not gaining as much territory as they wanted (resources are important to fuel the growing industrial economy), as well as the humiliation they faced at the hands of Australia (and the UK) when they refused the Racial Equality Clause is important to understand.

Resources to Use:

Racial Equality Amendment, Japan | Encyclopedia.com

Wilson and the Racial Equality Clause – Guernica

A Century Later: The Treaty Of Versailles And Its Rejection Of Racial Equality

Making Sense of the War (Japan)

Chinese Perspective

At the time of the Paris Peace Conference, there were two governments claiming to be the legitimate government of China: the Beiyang government in Beijing, and Dr Sun Yat-Sen's Guangzhou based Kuomintang (KMT) movement. However, they worked together to create the united diplomatic team that would plead China's case in Paris. In January 1915, Japan presented a list of demands to Chinese President Yuan Shih-k'ai, known as the "Twenty-one Demands," seeking to assert and expand Japanese control over various regions of China that the country had interest in.

Among these regions was Shandong Province, a stipulation that garnered much opposition within China, Chief delegate and Foreign Minister Lu Cheng-hsiang, who had signed one of the treaties resulting from the Twenty-one Demands, headed the Chinese delegation. Students and others opposed to Japanese expansionist policies saw him as a worrisome addition to the delegation given that Chinese territoriality was being called into question at the peace talks with the Shandong Province issue. Also, in the delegation were Wellington Koo and Cao Rulin. Koo demanded that Japan return Shandong to China. He further called for an end to imperialist institutions such as extraterritoriality, legation guards, and foreign leaseholds. Despite American support, and his proclamations of self-determination, the western powers refused his claims. Inspired by Wilsonian rhetoric like the Fourteen Points Speech, nationalists in colonial and semi-colonial countries such as China launched campaigns to demand self-determination and international equality. However, public opinion in general seemed to be in accord with the peace talks. Then, in late April, word came that control of Shandong, formerly held by Germany, would be accorded to Japan and not China. Going directly against the sentiment of national unity, this development acted as a catalyst for the student organizations that firmly opposed the move. Thus, the Chinese delegation at the Paris Peace Conference was the only one not to sign the Treaty of Versailles at the final ceremony.

HINTS:

1. How did the lack of a unified government in China at the time influence the success of the talks?
2. Why didn't the Americans back the Chinese, as promised, in the final decision to grant Japan, Chinese territory?

Resources to Use:

The Versailles Treaty's Immediate Repercussions (see China section)

V.K. Wellington Koo and the History of an International Attaché

Koo, V. K. Wellington | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

"When we spoke at Versailles": Lou Tseng-Tsiang and the Chinese Delegation at the 1919 Paris Peace Conference, Global Histories

Labour (China) | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

Chinese students protest the Treaty of Versailles (the May Fourth Incident), 1919 | Global Nonviolent Action Database

Papers Relating to the Foreign Relations of the United States, The Paris Peace Conference, 1919, Volume V

Australian Perspective

The delegation was led by Prime Minister Billy Hughes. During the war, there was great popular support for Australia's involvement in the war, it was not universal. In particular, the issue of conscription created great debate in the Australian community. Australian troops fighting overseas enlisted voluntarily and at first there was great enthusiasm for enlistment. However, the huge toll of deaths and the length of the war meant that by 1916 the number of volunteers was not sufficient to meet the requirements of the British military command. Australian soldiers fought in Turkey, Belgium and France. Australian involvement in World War I is synonymous with the legend of the Anzacs (ANZAC = Australian and New Zealand Army Corps). The name became famous with the landing of the Corps on the Gallipoli Peninsula, Turkey on 25 April 1915. It was the first military engagement in which significant numbers of Australians fought and died as Australian nationals. The Anzacs were part of an Allied campaign against the Turks to control the Dardanelles (the straits that connect the Black Sea and the Mediterranean Sea) and thus open the way to Constantinople and Eastern Europe. The Gallipoli campaign resulted in the deaths of 7,600 Australians and 2,500 New Zealanders and the wounding of 19,000 Australians and 5,000 New Zealanders. Despite the defeat, the legend attached to the heroism, comradeship and valour of the soldiers, stretcher-bearers, medical officers and others involved remains a source of Australian pride and national identity. More than 60,000 Australians were killed during the war. By 1920, about 90,000 Australian ex-servicemen were living with a permanent disability. This was a disproportionately high number of casualties for Australia's population. Australia's 60,000 official war dead represented 1.2 per cent of Australia's people compared to America's 117,000 casualties (0.1 per cent of its population). Prisoners of war included 4,044 of whom 397 died while captive.

The Australian delegation wanted war reparations, annexation of German New Guinea and the rejection of the Japanese racial equality proposal. Japan proposed including a "racial equality clause" to the Covenant of the League of Nations which stated, "the equality of nations being a basic principle of the League of Nations, the High Contracting Parties agree to accord as soon as possible to all alien nationals of states, members of the League, equal and just treatment in every respect making no distinction, either in law or in fact, on account of their race or nationality." Australia lobbied Great Britain to defend Australia's "White Australia Policy," resulting in Japan turning away from the west and pursuing a more militant nationalism. Hughes did obtain a class C mandate for New Guinea. The Mandate system was created by the Big Four within the League of Nations before the Treaty of Versailles was even signed. This was an attempt to stop the cycle of war and fighting over conquered land of the Ottomans and the Germans by giving away it to the winners of the war so that "these responsible nations" could manage them and they might gradually develop and mature to earn independence. Some nations were close to being able to govern themselves (Class A Mandates like Palestine, Jordan, Iraq, Lebanon and Syria, others at medium stages (Class B: Kamerun, Tanganyika and others with no hope soon of self- determination (Class C: New Guinea, Nauru, SW Africa..) President Wilson was offended by Australian territorial demands and questioned their motivation in profiting off of Germany's defeat in order to extend its sovereignty as far north of the equator.

HINTS:

1. Australia's White Australia policy is important to understanding why they were so against the Racial Equality Clause.

2. Australia is a member of the British commonwealth; being part of the British empire. Understanding the relationship between Great Britain and Australia is key to understanding Australia foreign policy at the time.

Resources:

Treaty of Versailles | Australian War Memorial

Peace Treaty – MoAD Learning Activities And Resources

1919: The triumph of Billy Hughes | The Strategist

Australia and the Paris Peace Conference - Anzac Portal

Versailles Treaty | National Museum of Australia

Versailles—How Australia demanded colonies of its own as spoils of war – Solidarity Online

Romania: Queen Marie

Before joining World War I, Queen Marie (a Princess at the beginning of the war) urged the government to join the Entente. On August 16, 1916, Romania declared war against Austria-Hungary. Three months later, Romania's capital, Bucharest, was taken over by the Central Powers. Unexpected events during the war, forced Romania to sign an armistice with the Central Powers. However, this treaty would not be signed by the King of Romania and did not take effect. Romania rejoined the war on Entente side (again) one day before the war ended. During the beginning stages of the Paris Peace Conference, Romania pushed for the independence of Romania. However, Romania was not treated fairly since they were seen as a country who switched sides during the war.

Queen Marie privately traveled to Paris where she convinced many world leaders into treating Romania fairly. Although her actions were helpful for Romania, the country did not get the war reparations they wanted. Romania refused to sign the Treaty of Versailles until changes were made in favor of Romania. Not getting what they wanted, the Romanian government resigned. A newly formed government signed the Treaty. Romania never got the land they wanted after the war.

- Hint: Look at the aftermath of the treaty between Hungary and Romania.
- Hint: Look up the Alliance Treaty of 1916 between Romania, UK, France, Russia, and Italy. See how later actions from Romania hurt this treaty and made Romania seem to be an untrustworthy country.
- Hint: Look at how Russia's actions toward the end of WWI played a major impact on the actions taken by Romania. (Key Word: Bolshevik Revolution)

Resources:

When The World Met Queen Marie of Romania

Romania | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

Romania enters World War I | August 27, 1916 | HISTORY

The political and diplomatic battle of Romania at the Paris Peace Conference (1919)

Centenary of the Versailles Treaty and Queen Marie of Romania

Queen Marie of Romania and the American President Woodrow Wilson

Ho Chi Minh - Vietnam

Born to a poor country scholar in the village of Kim Lien, Vietnam, Ho Chi Minh found his way to social activism as lowly paid worker in France. At the conclusion of World War 1, he led a delegation of Vietnamese living in France and addressed an eight-point petition to the representatives of the great powers at the Versailles Peace Conference. The petition sought:

1. General amnesty for natives who had been condemned for political activity.

2. Reform of Indochinese justice by granting natives similar judicial privileges as the Europeans.

3. Freedom of press and speech.

4. Freedom of association and assembly.

5. Freedom to emigrate and to travel abroad.

6. Freedom of education, and creation of technical schools for the native population.

7. Replacement of regime with random rules by regime of law.

8. A permanent delegation of native people elected to attend French parliament and represent needs of the natives.

His proposals would not have meant independence for Vietnam, but instead called for greater equity, more basic freedoms, and Vietnamese representation in the colonial government. This act brought no response from the peacemakers, but it made him a hero to many politically conscious Vietnamese.

Additional Resources:

Ho Chi Minh seeks Vietnamese independence (1919)

How Ho Chi Minh Combined Communism and Nationalism in Pursuit of a 'New World Order'

Indochinese Workers in France (Indochina) | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

Indochina | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

The Myth of the Wilsonian Moment | Wilson Center

Jan Smuts – South Africa

Born in 1870 in South Africa (then a British colony) Smuts was educated in England. During World War I he rejoined the South African army and led them into battles against the Germans in East Africa. He did work with the English in 1917 as a strategist in the war against Germany. At Versailles, he was the representative for South Africa and was an advocate (supported) for reconciliation with Germany. However, he did believe that Germany was responsible for monetary damages. He was a supporter of U.S. President Woodrow Wilson and his idea of "peace without victory". He supported the idea of the 14 points and also was in favor of the "mandate" system where the League of Nations would take charge of Germany's overseas possessions after the war.

HINT: It is important to understand the complexity of the opinions that Smuts held- he supported Wilson and the League of Nations but was concerned about US power; he agreed with German reparations but also felt reconciliation was important; he wanted a South African voice at the table but did not support colored or black rights in South Africa.

Additional Sources:

Woodrow Wilson, Jan Smuts, and the Versailles Settlement (PDF in file) log in at school automatically, may ask for institution name off campus

Jan Smuts

https://digitalcommons.unomaha.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1588&context=studentwork (142 page article but worth skimming)

Indian delegation

India was given representation at the Treaty of Versailles even though it was not politically free from Great Britain. This was important as no other country that was not autonomous (not controlled by another country) was given this right. Montagu and Singh were also included in the Indian delegation to the Paris Peace Conference of 1919. Also included as technical advisers were: Arthur Hirtzel, Assistant Under-Secretary of State for India; J. Dunlop Smith, Political Officer of the India Office; and L. Kershaw, Secretary to the Financial and Statistical Section of the India Office.

The Indian plenipotentiaries signed the peace treaties alongside representatives of other sovereign states on the basis of legal equality of status. As a signatory of the Treaty of Versailles, India was granted automatic entry to the League of Nations. India's delegation supported the Treaty and Wilson's 14 points and was the only colony to be included in the League of Nations that was not self-governing. Gandhi was supportive of the newly created Indian National Congress who were not allowed to be represented at Versailles as they were asking for freedom to create their own government not under Great Britain's control. Gandhi was very frustrated by this and as a result, began a series of non-violent protests to rid India of Great Britain's occupation.

Hints:

1. Why would India feel that they deserved self-determination? What was their role in the war?
2. Be able to articulate how it must have seemed hypocritical that France and the US did not apply the same values towards overseas colonies, as they implemented in their own nations. Don't the values of self-determination (Wilson) and Liberté, égalité, fraternité, French for "liberty, equality, fraternity", [the national motto of France] apply to the Indians and all colonized peoples?
3. What was the Amritsar Massacre that occurred in April 1919 and how would this change Gandhi's demands and attitudes towards the British?

Resources:

End of WW1 and Treaty of Versailles • India's Contribution to World War 1 • MyLearning

India and WWI: Piecing together the impact of the Great War on the subcontinent - South Asia @ LSE

1919 Paris Peace Conference Centennial: Recollecting India's Representation and Participation

Ottoman Empire (later the Republic of Turkey) - Kemal Mustafa (Ataturk)

Kemal was a highly intelligent, brave and charismatic leader. He fought in the front lines during the first world war and successfully held off the Australian, New Zealand and British forces from taking the Ottoman capital Constantinople (Istanbul). After the defeat of the enemies who attacked his country, he erected a memorial to honor them with these words inscribed on it:

"Those heroes that shed their blood and lost their lives ... You are now lying in the soil of a friendly country. Therefore rest in peace. There is no difference between the Johnnies [British] and the Mehmets [Turkish] to us where they lie side by side here in this country of ours ... You, the mothers who sent their sons from faraway countries, wipe away your tears; your sons are now lying in our bosom and are in peace. After having lost their lives on this land they have become our sons as well."

After WWI, disgusted by the weak leadership of Turkish politicians, Kemal led Turkish forces against invading Greek, Italian and French forces, ultimately winning and forcing them to sign a new treaty in 1923, which established modern Turkey. After this the Turkish people began calling him 'Ataturk': the father of the Turks.

Hint: Read the above quote from Kemal Mustafa – what words would you use to describe him?

Hint: How might Kemal Mustafa react to Europeans' mainstream anti-Islamic prejudices?

Additional Resources:

BBC - History - Kemal Atatürk (1881-1938)

Ottoman Empire signs treaty with Allies | October 30, 1918 | HISTORY

The End of the Ottoman Empire - Understanding the Treaties of Sèvres and Lausanne

Partition of the Ottoman Empire | History of Western Civilization II

Ataturk and Turkish Independence | History of Western Civilization II

Ottoman Empire in World War I: A Detailed Summary - History Crunch

Paris Peace Conference 1919: The 100 Years' Crisis in post-Ottoman lands

The Paris Peace Conference and its Consequences

Middle East: T.E. Lawrence

Before joining World War I, the Arab states had been promised independence from Great Britain if they helped fight against the Ottoman Empire, an ally of Germany. One of the British officers, T.E. Lawrence, encouraged the Arabs to revolt against the Ottomans. Fighting alongside the Arabs during the war, TE Lawrence pushed for Arab independence during the Paris Peace Conference. However, a secret agreement between Great Britain and France said that France would control Syria if the Ottoman Empire fell. Great Britain and France carved up the Middle East. Syria, Lebanon, and Turkish Cilicia were given to France. Britain gained Iraq, Palestine, and Jordan. Fighting for the Arabs, TE Lawrence was only able to help keep the leaders on the thrones for Iraq and Jordan. In the end, the Arab point of view was mostly ignored.

Hint: Look at the relationship between the Arabs' pleas and the American responses.
Hint: Research how this impacted the region in the future.
Hint: Research the role of Prince Feisal at the Paris Peace Conference.

Resources:

Paris Peace Conference - 1919 - and T.E. Lawrence

T. E. Lawrence and the Arab Cause at the Paris Peace Conference

The Middle Eastern Prince Who Tried to Change the Treaty of Versailles

The Power of Broken Promises: Wilson's Fourteen Points and U.S.-Arab Relations

Zionist Perspective

A delegation of the Zionist Organization led by Chaim Weizmann presents the case for a Jewish homeland in Palestine to the Paris Peace Conference at the conclusion of World War I. The statement, which included suggested boundaries, proposed that the newly established British Mandate should promote Jewish immigration and settlement, encourage self-government and ensure religious freedoms. The British had already made it clear that they supported a new Jewish state with the Balfour Declaration in 1916. In response to the decisions by the international community before and during the conference, Arabs who had no say in what happened at the conference or in how the former Ottoman territory was carved up and divided by the French and the British. The Mandate system was created by the Big Four within the League of Nations before the Treaty of Versailles was even signed. This was an attempt to stop the cycle of war and fighting over conquered land of the Ottomans and the Germans by giving away it to the winners of the war so that "these responsible nations" could manage them and they might gradually develop and mature to earn independence. Some nations were close to being able to govern themselves (Class A Mandates like Palestine, Jordan, Iraq, Lebanon and Syria, others at medium stages (Class B: Kamerun, Tanganyika and others with no hope of self- determination (Class C: New Guinea, Nauru, SW Africa..) After WWII, this territory would gain international support for forming its own nation, Israel, in 1948, further dislocating Palestinians throughout the region.

HINTS:

1. Arabs are protesting the meddling of the international community into the region. You however are confident that the Jews can live peacefully within Palestine with your Muslim neighbors, near both of your holy sites (You may want to include the names of the important holy sites, examples of European anti-Semitism before 1919, and also the statistics on Jewish migration into Palestine before and during 1919.)
2. But you do not care about this perspective. Your people have been persecuted for centuries in Europe and 3000 years ago this territory was yours—forget that the Ottomans (Muslims) have been there since the 1400's. Your holy places of worship are still here. [Note: The Holocaust has not happened yet so you can't talk about it other than to perhaps say *anti-Semitism* in Europe could get worse.]

Additional Resources:

Zionist Organization Statement on Palestine at the Paris Peace Conference | Jewish Virtual Library

Faisal–Weizmann agreement - Wikipedia

Zionists Present Case at Paris Peace Conference | CIE

Balfour Declaration | HISTORY

The Treaty of Versailles: A gathering of hope that gave way to hell on earth - The Jewish Chronicle

Blaise Diagne (Haitian) – Pan-Africanist

As the first African elected to the French National Assembly and hold a political post in The French government, Blaise often criticized oppression and discrimination of the black population in the colonies right at the start of his career as a customs agent in France. As the Versailles Peace Treaty deliberations were in progress, Diagne and other Pan-Africanists with funding from American Civil Rights and other organizations like the NACCP convened a Pan African Congress.

With an attendance record of approximately sixty representatives from sixteen nations, protectorates, and colonies, the congress attracted delegates with little, if any, first-hand knowledge of the African continent. Conference participants adopted a resolution calling for the drafting of a code of law "for the international protection of the natives of Africa." While congress attendees insisted that African natives should be allowed eventually to participate in their own government, they did not demand African self-determination. Despite the moderate nature of the demands, the European and American powers represented at the Versailles Peace Conference remained noncommittal.

HINT: Black Representatives from the Caribbean, North America and Africa all are proponents of these ideas.

HINT: Be sure to address the idea of self-determination.

HINT: Some of the Africans will address ideas of Negritude and Pan-Africanism. What does this mean and why is it significant?

Additional Resources:

The Pan-African Congresses, 1900-1945 | BlackPast.org

Blaise Diagne (1872-1934) | BlackPast.org

Pan-African Congresses.

African-American History Month: First Pan-African Congress

Conflicts of Interest: The 1919 Pan-African Congress and the Wilsonian Moment

Brazil - Epitacio de Silva Pessoa

Brazil was eager to expand it's economy to take advantage of gaps in the world trade left by Europe during WWI. Ignoring German warnings, putting profit before the lives of its people, Brazil traded with countries at war with Germany and subsequently lost many merchant ships to German U-boat attacks. After the USA declared war on Germany it seemed almost inevitable that Germany would lose. Keen to reap the rewards of victory, desperate to join the war before it was over, Brazil quickly changed its near pacifist constitution. Using the Germany U-boat attacks as an official justification Brazil joined WWI on October 26, 1917. A Brazilian official declared that this war was necessary as they were fighting for "… [a] better world … liberty…lasting peace … equal rights … justice and equity." This was more as a declaration for support of the USA, as it imitated Wilson's own feelings, than any real shift in Brazilian foreign policy. The fact that Brazil only sent one medical unit and some airmen demonstrates that. Its "participation" in the war was rewarded with a seat at the post-war bargaining table (as a 'Versailles ally' of economically powerful USA). Epitacio de Silva Pessoa was not Brazil's first choice to represent them at Versailles, however the original man did not want the job. He was also not a man of the Brazilian people, instead he was more interested in looking after the interests of the powerful, corrupt and rich of Brazil. During WWI, with Europe distracted by the fighting, Brazil's industries had done well – however with the war over the Brazilian economy was again starting to suffer and so needed loans from the USA. Subsequently, he fully supported the aims of the USA at Versailles.

Hint: Why would Brazil be so keen to want to impress the USA?

Hint: What would Brazil's main objectives be at Versailles (global liberty or money?)

Hint: What dangers might Brazil face now that European countries was no longer fighting each other?

RESOURCES:

Brazil declares war on Germany | October 26, 1917 | HISTORY

Latin America in World War I (skim to read just the section more than halfway down on Brazil during and after the war)

Pessoa, Epitácio | International Encyclopedia of the First World War

Korean Perspective

Korea at the time was a colony of the Japanese, a status that had been recognized by the Americans in 1905, in return for Japanese recognition of the Philippines as an American colony. President Wilson's called for "self-determination" led the Koreans to believe that this notion applied to them and with the beginning of the Paris Peace talks, on March 1st, 1919 the Koreans planned a peaceful march protesting Japanese rule. The move was made largely by Korea's teachers, Christian pastors and professional men. Participants in the demonstration were asked to carry homemade flags and to chant "may Korea live a thousand years." It was a day that was to become a great day of remembrance and mourning. The march was about 500,000 strong and witnessed by some American citizens. Japan's agents in Korea labeled the demonstrations as riots. Troops fired into the demonstrators. Japanese forces attacked and burned Christian churches. 6,670 Koreans died, 14,611 were wounded, and 52,770 arrested. Protestors were arrested, jailed and tortured for standing up for Korean independence having taken Wilson at his word. The Japanese would not permit a delegation to travel to Paris, however three unofficial representatives, including Kim Gyu-sik, a Korean nationalist and secretly, the Korean government in exile's foreign minister, were there posing as YMCA delegates. They gained a meeting with one of the Americans, giving him the "Petition of the Korean People and Nation for Liberation from Japan and for the Reconstitution of Korea as an Independent State" and the "Claims of the Korean People and Nation." The concerns raised, namely, the desire for Korean independence, were never brought to President Wilson, and little came of their visit. Before leaving he gave a speech which asked whether Woodrow Wilson meant what he said about self-determination and criticized the French who pretended to love justice but cared little about 20 million Koreans suffering under Japanese colonial oppression which included censorship and forced rice exports to Japan, leaving their own people hungry. Kim would later become a Communist and describe the hypocrisy of the Americans.

HINTS:

1. Emphasize Korean nationalism, but this is not just a desire for independence but a desire to help the well-being of the Korean people—they have been oppressed by a cruel occupier, gone hungry in order to fill the bellies of the Japanese, and have been unable to protest even peacefully. Read the link which contains Young Park's Manifesto. Great language to use here!
2. You will want to talk about how the Americans and the French are hypocritical. Why don't the values of self-determination (Wilson) and Liberté, égalité, fraternité, French for "liberty, equality, fraternity", [the national motto of France] apply to the Koreans?

Resources:

Koreans ignored at 1919 Paris Peace Conference - The Korea Times

Kim Kyu-sik – The Unsung Heroes Who Fought for Independence!

Korea Appeals to Wilson for Freedom; "Hermit Kingdom," - The New York Times
The Versailles Treaty's Immediate Repercussions (see the Korea section)

Korea during World War I

Zionist Perspective

A delegation of the Zionist Organization led by Chaim Weizmann presents the case for a Jewish homeland in Palestine to the Paris Peace Conference at the conclusion of World War I. The statement, which included suggested boundaries, proposed that the newly established British Mandate should promote Jewish immigration and settlement, encourage self-government and ensure religious freedoms. The British had already made it clear that they supported a new Jewish state with the Balfour Declaration in 1916. In response to the decisions by the international community before and during the conference, Arabs who had no say in what happened at the conference or in how the former Ottoman territory was carved up and divided by the French and the British. The Mandate system was created by the Big Four within the League of Nations before the Treaty of Versailles was even signed. This was an attempt to stop the cycle of war and fighting over conquered land of the Ottomans and the Germans by giving away it to the winners of the war so that "these responsible nations" could manage them and they might gradually develop and mature to earn independence. Some nations were close to being able to govern themselves (Class A Mandates like Palestine, Jordan, Iraq, Lebanon and Syria, others at medium stages (Class B: Kamerun, Tanganyika and others with no hope of self- determination (Class C: New Guinea, Nauru, SW Africa..) After WWII, this territory would gain international support for forming its own nation, Israel, in 1948, further dislocating Palestinians throughout the region.

HINTS:

3. Arabs are protesting the meddling of the international community into the region. You however are confident that the Jews can live peacefully within Palestine with your Muslim neighbors, near both of your holy sites (You may want to include the names of the important holy sites, examples of European anti-Semitism before 1919, and also the statistics on Jewish migration into Palestine before and during 1919.)
4. But you do not care about this perspective. Your people have been persecuted for centuries in Europe and 3000 years ago this territory was yours—forget that the Ottomans (Muslims) have been there since the 1400s. Your holy places of worship are still here. [Note: The Holocaust has not happened yet so you can't talk about it other than to perhaps say *anti-Semitism* in Europe could get worse.]

Additional Resources:

Zionist Organization Statement on Palestine at the Paris Peace Conference | Jewish Virtual Library

Faisal–Weizmann agreement - Wikipedia

Zionists Present Case at Paris Peace Conference | CIE

Balfour Declaration | HISTORY

The Treaty of Versailles: A gathering of hope that gave way to hell on earth - The Jewish Chronicle